Ten Patients, and Another

By Rafael Campo

NOTE: *Each stanza should be presented in a different persona (all stanzas are spoken by doctors or medical personnel within a hospital setting. Stanza VIII may be a phone conversation – Be creative in developing the characters)*

I. Mrs. G (Pg 61-71)

The patient is a sixty-odd-year-old
White female, who presents with fever, cough,
And shaking chills. No further history
Could be elicited; she doesn't speak.
The patient's social history was non-
Contributory: someone left her here.
The intern found a bruise behind her ear.
She then became quite agitated, and
Began to sob without producing tears.
She's resting quietly
On Haldol, waiting for a bed upstairs.

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INTRODUCTION

Medicine is about providing care *to* ***people****. Yes, the core of medical education is science — anatomy, physiology, pathology. Yet patient care is* ***more*** *than just the memorization of facts and figures; it requires empathy, it requires the doctor to feel. They must remember that behind every "patient" lies a real human being — a mother, father, son, daughter, friend. Only when one looks beyond the* ***patient*** *and sees the* ***person*** *can physicians truly make a difference.*

Ten Patients, and Another by Raphael Campo tackles the intersection of social and medical issues, addressing topics of alcoholism, child, sexual and drug abuse, domestic violence, AIDS, racial prejudice, homelessness, and homophobia. Doctors, while medically trained, often are ill-prepared to cope with the social issues they face. We must do better.

II. Jamal

The patient is a three-year-old black male,
The full-term product of a pregnancy
That was, according to his grandmother,
Unplanned and maybe complicated by
Prenatal alcohol exposure. Did
OK, developmentally delayed
But normal weights and heights, until last week

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When he ingested what's turned out to be
Cocaine, according to the lab results;
His grandmother had seen him with
Some baby powder on his face and hands
Before he started seizing.
The nurse is getting DSS involved.
The mom? She left it on the kitchen table.
That's her -- the one who sings to him all night.

III. HK

The patient is a twenty-nine-year-old
Black man.
Upon returning from his shift – the patient is
A night nurse at a local hospital --
He was attacked by two assailants. Males,
White, late teens, shouting threats and epithets.
He thinks they followed him from work. He turned,
Attempting to respond, when he was struck
With two blunt objects in succession. One
Was glass; we know because some fragments were
Extracted from the wounds.
The surgeons didn't want to operate
Until they had more information. CT scans
Revealed free blood inside the abdomen.
What's scary is he isn't even gay.

IV. Kelly

The patient is a twelve-year-old white female.
She's gravida zero*, no STD's.
She'd never even had a pelvic. One
Month nausea and vomiting.
No fever, chills, malaise.
Her school performance has been worsening.
She states that things at home are fine.
On physical exam, she cried but was
Cooperative.
Her pelvic was remarkable for scars
At six o'clock, no hymen visible,
Some uterine enlargement. Pregnancy
Tests positive times two. She says it was
Her dad. He's sitting in the waiting room.

No previous pregnancies

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V. John Doe

An elderly white male, unresponsive.
Looks homeless. Maybe he's been here before.
No chart. No history. His vital signs
Were barely present, temperature was down
Near ninety, pressure ninety over palp;
The pulse was forty, best as they could tell.
They'll hook him up to a monitor before
They warm him up. I didn't listen to
His lungs—I bet I'd hear a symphony
In there. I couldn't check his pupils since
His lids were frozen shut, but there were no
External signs of trauma to the head.
They found this picture of a woman with
Two tiny kids still pinned inside his coat.
It's only three a.m. The night's young. If
He's lucky, by tomorrow he'll be dead.

VI. S.W.

Extending from her left ear down her jaw,
The lac was seven centimeters long.
She told me that she slipped and struck her face

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Against the kitchen floor. The floor was wet
Because she had been mopping it. I guessed
She'd had to wait for many hours since
The clock read nearly midnight; who mops floors
So late? Her little girl kept screaming in
Her husband's thick, impatient arms: he knocked
Three times, each time to ask when we'd be done.
I infiltrated first with lidocaine.
She barely winced, and didn't start to cry
Until the sixteenth stitch went in and we
Were almost through. I thought my handiwork
Was admirable. I yawned, then offered her
Instructions on the care of wounds. She left.

VII. Manuel

In Trauma 1, a gay Latino kid –
I think he's seventeen – is getting tubed
For respiratory failure. "Sleeping pills
And Tylenol," I translated for him
As he was wheeled in. His novio *(boyfriend)*
Explained that when he'd told his folks about
It all, they threw him out. Like trash. They lived

Together underneath the overpass
Of Highway 101 for seven weeks,
The stars obstructed from their view.
A viejita *(old woman)* from the neighborhood
Brought tacos to them secretly. Last night,
With eighteen-wheelers roaring overhead,
He whispered that he'd lost the will to live.
He pawned his crucifix to get the pills.

VIII: PP

Another Aids Admission. This one's great:
They bring him in strapped down because he threw
His own infected s*** at them – you better bring
Your goggles! – and a mask, we think he's got
TB. He's pissed as hell. Apparently,
He wants to die at home but somebody
Keeps calling 911. A relative
Back home in Iowa, or some damn place.
Just keep him snowed with Ativan – believe
You me – you do not want to get to know
This *guy*. Kaposi's* all over, stinks –

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Incontinent of course. How long
Before you get down here? Because his nurse
Is driving me insane. Of course, we got
Blood cultures . . . yeah, a gas – OK, I'll stick
him one more time. The things you do for love.

** **Kaposi's** sarcoma (KS) is a type of cancer that can form masses in the skin*

IX. Tommy

A twenty-one-year-old white man brought in
By ambulance – in hypotensive shock,
Shot in the back while buying drugs from three
Black men. The cord must be involved:
His legs are paralyzed,
And all sensation from below
The level of the entry site is lost.
They left him in the street for dead; I heard
Them say an alley dog was lapping up
His blook like milk when he was found. Before
He goes to surgery, he has to give
Informed consent, which he's refused to do
Thus far. He states he'd rather die than be

Dependent on his family for care.
They're questioning his competence, of course.
They're waiting on his folks. His wife just stares.

X. Maria

This *patient* gives us a confusing
History. It sounds like she's been pregnant
Approximately thirty weeks, although
She can't recall her last LMP*. No pain,
But bleeding for about two days. Of course
She hasn't had prenatal care, and God
Only knows where the father is. She works
Two jobs that keep her on her feet all day.
She's been in the United States six months,
And doesn't speak a word of English. Bet
You she's illegal.
I think we need an ultrasound to tell us more.
Her uterus can tell us more than she can.

Last Menstrual Period

XI. Jane Doe #2

They found her unresponsive in the street

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Beneath a lamplight I imagined made
Her seem angelic, regal even, clean.
She must have been around sixteen. She died
Who knows how many hours earlier
That day, the heroin inside her like
A vengeful dream about to be fulfilled.
Her hands were crossed about her chest, as though
Raised up in self-defense; I tried to pry
Them open to confirm the absence of
A heartbeat, but in death she was so strong,
As resolute as she was beautiful.
I traced the track marks on her arms instead,
Then pressed my thumb against her bloodless lips,
So urgent was my need to know. I felt
The quiet left by a departing soul.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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